Childcare cost burden on single mothers

A Nationwide Problem

Across the United States, single mothers face a disproportionate burden of childcare costs—often spending far more than the 7% of income defined as affordable by the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (HHS)

Top 5 Burdened counties

In the five most burdened states, the annual cost of infant childcare **exceeds 73%** of the median earnings for women—placing an overwhelming financial strain on single mothers.

Top 5 Most Burdened Counties by Annual Infant Care Cost Burden (2022)

	Rank	State	County	Weekly Infant Care Cost	Female Median Earnings (2022)	Annual Burden (% of Female Earnings)	Single-Mom Households in Area (<6 years)
0	1	Ohio	Athens County	$295.00	$18,556	82.7%	400
1	2	California	Santa Barbara County	$452.53	$29,640	79.4%	7,961
2	3	Oregon	Benton County	$340.19	$24,074	73.5%	496
3	4	Virginia	Harrisonburg City	$187.51	$13,273	73.5%	490
4	5	California	Santa Cruz County	$476.88	$33,834	73.3%	3,319

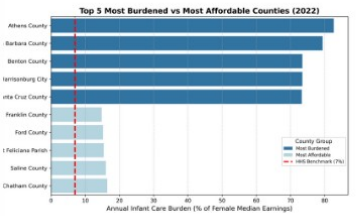
Median Female Earnings

$27,363/year

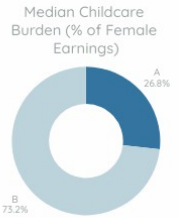
Infant care cost

Median Weekly Infant Care Cost:
$140.35/week
Estimated Annual Infant Care Cost:
$7,298/year

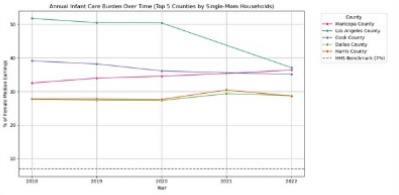
Why is this the standard?



Even the so-called 'affordable' counties fail to meet the federal 7% affordability standard—childcare is effectively unaffordable everywhere for single-mother households with no additional income support.



26.8% of a single mother's income goes to infant care—nearly 4x what's considered affordable.



In counties with the largest single-mother populations, the annual childcare burden remains persistently high—showing little improvement over time and still far exceeding the 7% affordability benchmark set by the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (HHS).

How do we fix this?

- **Childcare Subsidies** | Fund low-cost or free childcare for low-income families.
- **Raise Wages** | Ensure pay equity and living wages for working moms.
- **Public Investment** | Expand access to early education and childcare centers.
- **Policy Action** | Cap childcare costs relative to income.
- **Local Support** | Strengthen community-based resources for single parents.